ELPA question types: *know the question before you read.*

Every English language proficiency test asks the same eighteen kinds of questions. This guide shows each one: what it is really asking, the words that give it away, three moves that work, and a worked example with every answer choice explained.

18 question types

5 steps for every question

72 answer choices explained

Five steps that work on every question

Most wrong answers come from skipping step 1. Name the question type first, and you know what kind of answer to look for.

1. **Name it** — Read the question stem. Which of the 18 types is it?
2. **Mark it** — Circle the question word and the key word: who, why, mainly, first, closest.
3. **Find it** — Go back to the text, picture or speaker. Put a finger on the evidence.
4. **Predict it** — Say your own answer before you read the choices.
5. **Cross out** — Remove choices that are too small, not in the text, opposite, or true but off-topic.

Four ways wrong answers are built

Test writers make wrong choices on purpose. Learn the four shapes and they stop looking attractive.

Too small

True, but only one detail. It is not the whole idea.

Not in the text

Sounds reasonable, but the passage never says it. Look for proof.

The opposite

Uses the right words but reverses the meaning. Check small words like not, only, never.

True but off-topic

A fact from the passage that does not answer this question.

1 Main Idea

Understanding the whole text

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

The one big idea the whole passage is about. If the passage had a title, this would be the title.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

What is the passage mainly about?

Which statement best expresses the main idea?

What is the speaker mainly explaining?

THREE MOVES

1. Read the first and last sentences: the main idea often lives there.
2. Ask: what do ALL the sentences have in common?
3. Cross out choices that mention only one sentence.

The trap: Too small. A detail that is true but covers only one sentence.

TRY IT

Many schools in our town now have gardens. Students plant tomatoes, beans, and herbs in the spring. They water the plants and pull weeds after class. In the fall, the cafeteria uses the vegetables in lunch. The gardens teach students about food and give them healthy things to eat.

Which statement best expresses the main idea?

A Tomatoes grow better in spring than in fall.

This is not in the passage. It would be a new fact, not the main idea.

B School gardens help students learn and eat healthy food.

Yes. Planting, watering, and eating the food all connect to this one idea.

C The cafeteria is the best place to eat lunch.

The passage never says the cafeteria is the best place to eat.

D Weeds are a problem in every garden.

Weeds appear in one sentence, and the passage does not say they are a problem.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

Which title fits the passage best?

A Pulling Weeds

B Gardens That Grow Students and Lunch

A good title covers the whole passage. The first one is one small job, and the third is only one sentence.

C A Trip to the Cafeteria

2 Key Details

Understanding the whole text

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

One small fact the text states directly: who, what, where, when, how many. The answer is written in the text, word for word or close to it.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

Where does ___ happen?

Who does ___?

Which detail explains ___?

THREE MOVES

1. Circle the question word: where, who, when, how.
2. Find the sentence in the text that has the same key word.
3. Choose the answer that matches that sentence, not your memory.

The trap: A true place or person from a different sentence.

TRY IT

On Saturday morning, Maya rode the bus to the library with her brother Luis. They returned three books and borrowed four new ones. Then they ate lunch in the park near the fountain.

Where did Maya and Luis eat lunch?

A At the library

They were at the library earlier, but the lunch sentence names another place.

B On the bus

The bus took them to the library, not to lunch.

C In the park

Yes. The last sentence says they ate lunch in the park near the fountain.

D At home

The passage never mentions home.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

How many new books did they borrow?

A Three

B Four

The text says they returned three and borrowed four. Three is a detail from the same sentence, a trap.

C Seven

3 Cause and Effect

Understanding the whole text

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

One thing made another thing happen. The cause is why; the effect is what happened.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

Why does ___ happen?

What happens as a result of ___?

What happens because ___?

THREE MOVES

1. Look for signal words: because, so, as a result, since, therefore.
2. Put the two parts in this frame: ___ happened, so ___.
3. Check the order: the cause always comes first in time.

The trap: Reversed. The effect is offered as the cause.

TRY IT

Last week it rained for four days. The river rose over its banks, and water covered the road near the school. The bus could not use that road, so students arrived late.

Why did students arrive late?

A The school opened late.

Nothing in the passage says the school opened late.

B Water covered the road the bus uses.

Yes. The signal word so connects the blocked road to arriving late.

C It rained during lunch.

Rain is in the passage, but nothing says it rained at lunch, and that is not why they were late.

D The river was dry.

The opposite. The river rose.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

What happened as a result of the rain?

A The river rose over its banks.

The rain is the cause; the river rising is the first effect. The other two never happen in the text.

B The bus got a new road.

C Students were given a day off.

4 Sequence

Understanding the whole text

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

The order things happen in. Steps, events, or a day.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

Which ___ happened first?

What happens next?

What does ___ do after ___?

THREE MOVES

1. Circle the order words: first, next, then, after that, finally, before.
2. Number the steps 1, 2, 3 in the margin.
3. Find the step the question names, then look at the step that follows it.

The trap: A real step, but from the wrong place in the order.

TRY IT

To make a paper boat, first fold the paper in half. Next, fold the top corners to the middle. Then fold up the bottom edges on both sides. Finally, pull the boat open and press the bottom flat.

What happens right after the top corners are folded to the middle?

A Pull the boat open.

That is the last step, not the next one.

B Fold up the bottom edges.

Yes. Then comes right after Next, and it names this step.

C Fold the paper in half.

That is step 1. It happens before the corners.

D Press the bottom flat.

That is the last step too, after pulling the boat open.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

Which words show the correct order of the steps?

A Finally, first, then, next

B First, next, then, finally

First starts it, finally ends it. Read the middle words in the order of the text.

C Next, finally, first, then

5 Summarize

Understanding the whole text

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

The big ideas of the whole passage in one short sentence, in your own words. Shorter than the text, longer than a title.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

Which sentence best summarizes the selection?

THREE MOVES

1. Ask: who or what, and what happens, in one breath?
2. Cross out choices about only one detail.
3. Cross out choices with new ideas that are not in the text.

The trap: A single detail that sounds like a summary.

TRY IT

Bees visit flowers to drink nectar. While they drink, pollen sticks to their legs. When a bee lands on the next flower, some pollen falls off. This helps the flowers make seeds. Without bees, many plants could not grow new plants.

Which sentence best summarizes the passage?

A Bees drink nectar from many kinds of flowers.

True, but it is only the first sentence.

B Bees carry pollen between flowers, which helps plants make seeds.

Yes. It covers what bees do and why it matters.

C Pollen sticks to the legs of bees.

True, but it is one detail.

D Some plants cannot grow without sunlight.

Not in the passage, so it cannot summarize it.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

How is a summary different from a main idea?

A A summary retells the key points in order; a main idea is the one big point.

A main idea is one big point. A summary is short, but it includes the key points.

B A summary is longer than the passage.

C They are exactly the same thing.

6 Vocabulary in Context

Words and sentences

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

What a word means in THIS sentence, using the words around it as clues. You do not need to know the word.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

What does the word ____ mean in this sentence?

Which word is closest in meaning to ____?

Which word means about the same as ____?

THREE MOVES

1. Cover the word and read the sentence. What would fit?
2. Look for clue words in the next sentence: and, but, because.
3. Put each choice in place of the word. Does it still make sense?

The trap: A meaning that fits the word in another sentence but not this one.

TRY IT

The hikers were exhausted after climbing for six hours. They sat down on a rock and could not take another step.

What does the word exhausted mean in this sentence?

A very tired

Yes. Climbing for six hours and not being able to take another step are the clues.

B very hungry

Possible after hiking, but the passage gives no clue about food.

C very happy

The hikers are sitting down and cannot move, which does not sound happy.

D very lost

Nothing says they are lost.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

Which word is closest in meaning to enormous?

A tiny

B huge

Enormous means very, very big. Tiny is the opposite, a common trap.

C quiet

7 Reference Words

Words and sentences

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

Which noun a small word stands for: he, she, it, they, this, that.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

What does the word they, it, or this refer to?

THREE MOVES

1. Find the word in the sentence.
2. Look BACK for the nearest person or thing that matches in number (one or more) and kind (person or thing).
3. Put your answer in place of the small word and read it again.

The trap: A noun that is closer, but does not match.

TRY IT

Ana and her sister bought a puzzle at the market. They put it on the kitchen table and started to work on it that night.

What does the word it refer to?

A the market

They bought the puzzle at the market. You do not put the market on a table.

B the puzzle

Yes. Replace it with the puzzle: They put the puzzle on the kitchen table.

C the kitchen table

Closer to the word, but it comes after it. They put the table on the table makes no sense.

D the night

Night is a time. People do not put a time on a table.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

Who does the word They refer to?

A the market

B Ana and her sister

They means more than one person. Only Ana and her sister fits.

C the puzzle

8 Complete a Sentence

Words and sentences

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

Choose the word or words that make the sentence correct in meaning AND in grammar.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

Which word best completes the sentence?

Which words belong in the blank?

THREE MOVES

1. Read the whole sentence first, including after the blank.
2. Look for clue words: because, but, yesterday, every day.
3. Read the sentence aloud with each choice. Which sounds right?

The trap: A word that fits the meaning but the wrong form, or the right form but the wrong meaning.

TRY IT

The students were _____ because the test was easier than they expected.

Which word best completes the sentence?

A worried

Opposite. An easier test is not a reason to worry.

B relieved

Yes. Because the test was easier than expected, relieved fits.

C angry

Nothing in the sentence gives a reason to be angry.

D bored

Possible, but because does not point to boredom.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

Yesterday, Sam _____ his homework before dinner.

A finish

B finishes

C finished

Yesterday is a past-time clue, so the verb must be past: finished. The grammar clue decides this one.

undefined finishing

9 Inference

Thinking beyond the words

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

An answer the text does NOT say outright. You use clues in the text plus what you know to work it out.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

What does the passage suggest about ___?

What can the reader conclude about ___?

What does ___ most likely mean?

THREE MOVES

1. Underline two clues.
2. Ask: what do these clues add up to in real life?
3. Choose the answer with the most proof. The best inference could not be argued with.

The trap: A guess with no clue behind it.

TRY IT

Carlos put on his raincoat and boots. He picked up his umbrella and looked at the dark sky before he left the house.

What can the reader conclude?

A It is going to rain soon.

Yes. Raincoat, boots, umbrella, and a dark sky all point to rain.

B Carlos is going to swim.

Nothing in the text points to swimming.

C Carlos is late for school.

Nothing says he is late.

D It is a sunny day.

The opposite. The sky is dark.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

What can the reader conclude about Carlos?

A He expects bad weather.

He prepares for the weather. The other two have no clues.

B He dislikes his raincoat.

C He has never seen rain.

10 Text Evidence

Thinking beyond the words

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

Which line from the text proves an idea. Not what is true, but what PROVES it.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

Which sentence best supports the idea that ___?

THREE MOVES

1. Say the idea in your own words.
2. Check each sentence: does it show it, or only come near it?
3. Pick the sentence that shows it most directly.

The trap: A sentence from the passage that is true but proves a different idea.

TRY IT

Ms. Lee's class collected 200 cans for the food bank. Every student brought at least five cans, and some students brought more. Ms. Lee thanked the class for working together. The cans went to the food bank on Friday.

Which sentence best supports the idea that every student took part?

A Ms. Lee's class collected 200 cans for the food bank.

It gives the total, but not that everyone helped.

B Every student brought at least five cans, and some students brought more.

Yes. The word every proves that everyone took part.

C Ms. Lee thanked the class for working together.

It shows a thank-you, not that every student helped.

D The cans went to the food bank on Friday.

It tells when the cans went to the food bank, not who brought them.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

Which sentence best supports the idea that the class was generous?

A The cans went on Friday.

B Some students brought more than five cans.

Bringing more than you must is generous. The others are facts that do not show generosity.

C Ms. Lee is a teacher.

11 Author's Purpose

Thinking beyond the words

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

WHY the author wrote it: to inform, to persuade, to entertain, or to explain how to do something.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

Why did the author write this passage?

Why does the author include ____?

THREE MOVES

1. Ask: if I read this, what would I get? Facts, steps, a laugh, or a push to do something?
2. Commands such as wash, fold, and add point to steps.
3. Funny characters and a story point to entertain. Words like should and best point to persuade.

The trap: A purpose that fits another kind of writing.

TRY IT

Wash your hands for twenty seconds with soap and warm water. Scrub between your fingers and under your nails. Rinse well and dry with a clean towel. Clean hands help stop germs from spreading.

Why did the author write this passage?

A to tell a funny story

There are no characters and nothing funny.

B to explain how to wash hands

Yes. The passage gives steps in order, so its purpose is to explain how.

C to get readers to buy soap

It never mentions a brand or tells readers to buy anything.

D to describe a hospital

A hospital is not mentioned.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

A writer says, Every student should eat breakfast because it helps you learn. What is the purpose?

A to persuade

Should and a reason that urges the reader to act are the signs of persuasion.

B to entertain

C to describe a place

12 Paragraph Purpose

Thinking beyond the words

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

What job one paragraph does in the whole text: introduce, explain, give an example, show a change, give a result.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

What is the main purpose of paragraph ___?

How does the paragraph help explain ___?

What is one change that occurs during ___?

THREE MOVES

1. Read ONLY the paragraph the question names.
2. Say its job in one verb: describes, explains, compares, shows a change.
3. Check the choice against the paragraph, not the whole passage.

The trap: A choice about the other paragraph.

TRY IT

PARAGRAPH 1

Sea turtles lay eggs on beaches at night. A mother turtle digs a deep hole in the sand and lays about one hundred eggs. Then she covers the nest and returns to the ocean.

PARAGRAPH 2

Two months later, the baby turtles hatch. They climb out of the sand and crawl toward the bright water. Many are eaten by birds, so only a few reach adulthood.

What is the main purpose of paragraph 1?

A to describe how a mother sea turtle makes a nest

Yes. Paragraph 1 is about digging, laying, and covering the nest.

B to show why birds eat turtles

That is in paragraph 2, not paragraph 1.

C to explain how turtles swim

Swimming is never described.

D to compare turtles and birds

Nothing in the paragraph compares two animals.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

What is one change that happens in paragraph 2?

A Eggs hatch into baby turtles.

Two months later, the babies hatch. That is the change. Digging was in paragraph 1.

B The mother turtle digs a hole.

C The ocean dries up.

13 Comparison

Thinking beyond the words

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

How two things are the same or different. The key question is: similar, or different?

IT SOUNDS LIKE

What is one way that ___ and ___ are similar?

How are ___ and ___ alike or different?

THREE MOVES

1. Underline signals: both, also, like, the same (alike); but, unlike, while (different).
2. Make a two-column list from the text.
3. Check each choice against BOTH columns.

The trap: A true detail about only one of the two things.

TRY IT

Frogs and toads look alike, but they are different. Frogs have smooth, wet skin and long legs for jumping. Toads have dry, bumpy skin and shorter legs, so they walk or hop. Both animals lay eggs in water and eat insects.

What is one way that frogs and toads are similar?

A Both have smooth skin.

Only frogs have smooth skin.

B Both eat insects.

Yes. The word both signals a likeness: they eat insects.

C Both have long legs.

Only frogs have long legs.

D Both walk instead of jump.

Toads walk or hop; frogs jump.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

How are frogs and toads different?

A Frogs have smooth skin; toads have bumpy skin.

Different means one has it and the other does not. Both is the signal for the same.

B Both lay eggs in water.

C Both eat insects.

14 Character or Speaker

Thinking beyond the words

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

Why a person in the text does or says something, or what the speaker is like. Use their actions and words.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

Why does ___ do or say ___?

How does ___ feel about ___?

THREE MOVES

1. Ask: what is the person trying to do?
2. Read what the person does AND says; look for a reason in the text.
3. Choose a reason that fits what you know about the person.

The trap: A reason that does not match the character's actions.

TRY IT

Mr. Garcia, the bus driver, waited at the corner for two extra minutes. A boy was running toward the bus with his backpack open, and papers were falling out. "Take your time," Mr. Garcia called. "I'll wait."

Why did Mr. Garcia wait at the corner?

A He was lost.

Nothing says he is lost. He is waiting on purpose.

B He wanted to help a boy catch the bus.

Yes. A boy was running to the bus, and Mr. Garcia said, I will wait.

C The bus was broken.

The bus is not described as broken.

D He wanted to read.

Not in the passage.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

What kind of person is Mr. Garcia?

A patient and kind

He gave extra time and a kind word. Those actions show patience and kindness.

B angry and loud

C careless and late

15 Character's Feelings or Motives

Thinking beyond the words

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

How a character feels, or why they decide to do something. Feelings are shown by what the person does, says, or thinks.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

How does ___ feel about ___?

Why does ___ decide to ___?

THREE MOVES

1. Underline what the character does: shaking, smiling, shouting.
2. Match the clues to a feeling word you know.
3. Check the beginning AND the end: feelings can change.

The trap: A feeling the character had at the start, not the end.

TRY IT

After three weeks of practice, Dana stood at the edge of the pool. Her hands were shaking, but she took a deep breath and jumped in. When she came up, she was smiling. "I did it!" she shouted.

How does Dana feel at the end?

A proud

Yes. Smiling and shouting I did it after weeks of practice show pride.

B bored

Nothing in the text shows boredom.

C angry

She is smiling, not angry.

D confused

She knows exactly what she did.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

Why does Dana decide to jump?

A She practiced for three weeks and wants to try.

The motive is in the text: three weeks of practice. Her shaking hands show nerves, but she jumps anyway.

B Someone pushes her.

C The pool is closing.

16 Identify a Picture or Object

Pictures, graphs and explanations

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

Match a description, spoken or written, to the picture that shows it. Common in listening and in the early grades.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

Which picture shows ___?

Which ___ matches the description?

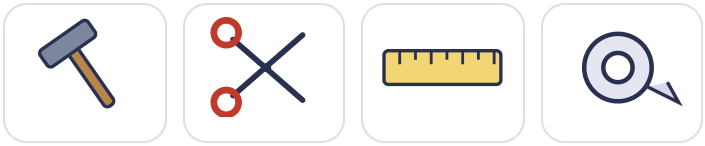
THREE MOVES

1. List every clue in the description: shape, parts, use.
2. Check each picture for ALL the clues, not just one.
3. Cross out pictures that miss even one clue.

The trap: A picture that matches one clue but misses another.

TRY IT

Description: It has two blades. People use it to cut paper.



A B C D

Which picture shows the object?

A Picture A

A hammer has a handle and a head, but no blades, and it is not used to cut.

B Picture B

Yes. Scissors have two blades and cut paper.

C Picture C

A ruler measures. It has no blades.

D Picture D

Tape sticks things together. It does not cut paper.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

You hear: It is used to measure how long something is. Which picture?

A hammer

B scissors

C ruler

Measure how long points to the ruler. Two clues: use (measure) and shape (flat, with marks).

17 Analyze a Visual

Pictures, graphs and explanations

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

Read a graph, chart, map or diagram and say what it shows. Title, labels and numbers are all clues.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

Which statement describes the information in the graph?

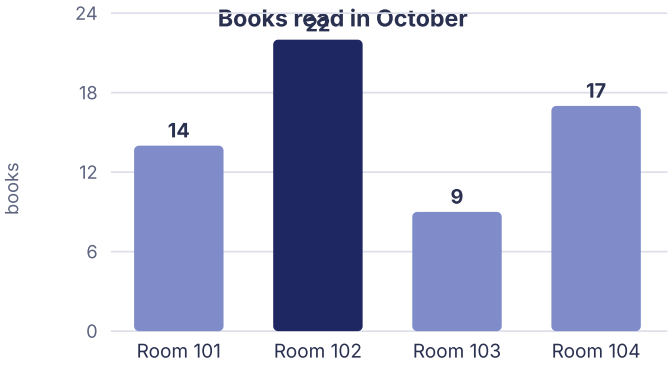
Which diagram shows ___?

THREE MOVES

1. Read the title first, then the labels.
2. Find the tallest and shortest bars, or the biggest and smallest numbers.
3. Check each statement against the numbers, not what looks about right.

The trap: A statement that sounds like the graph but reverses the numbers.

TRY IT



Which statement describes the information in the graph?

A Room 103 read the most books.

Room 103 read the fewest, 9 books.

B Room 102 read the most books.

Yes. Room 102 has the tallest bar, 22 books.

C Room 101 read more books than Room 104.

Room 101 read 14 and Room 104 read 17, so Room 104 read more.

D All four rooms read the same number of books.

The bars are different heights.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

How many more books did Room 102 read than Room 103?

A 13

22 minus 9 is 13. Read the two numbers from the graph, then subtract.

B 22

C 9

18 Understand an Explanation

Pictures, graphs and explanations

WHAT IT IS REALLY ASKING

How something works: a process, a machine, a natural cycle. You explain it back in your own words.

IT SOUNDS LIKE

How does ___ work?

Which statement best explains ___?

THREE MOVES

1. Number the stages in the order they happen.
2. Ask: what causes each stage?
3. Choose the answer that has the stages in the right order.

The trap: Right words, wrong order.

TRY IT

The sun heats water in lakes and oceans. The water turns into vapor and rises into the air. High in the sky, the vapor cools and forms clouds. When the clouds get heavy, water falls as rain.

Which statement best explains how clouds form?

A Rain pushes water up into the sky.

Backward. Rain falls down from clouds.

B Vapor rises, cools high in the sky, and forms clouds.

Yes. It has the stages in order: rise, cool, form clouds.

C Wind carries water from the clouds to the oceans.

Wind is not in the passage, and the order is wrong.

D Lakes freeze and float upward.

Not in the passage.

ALSO LOOKS LIKE

What makes water rise into the air?

A The sun heats it.

The first sentence gives the cause: the sun heats the water.

B Clouds pull it.

C Rain pushes it.

Quick reference

One line per question type. Print it, tape it inside a notebook, and check it before the test.

Type	It sounds like	Do this
Main Idea	What is the passage mainly about?	Say the whole passage as a short title
Key Details	Where does ___ happen?	Find the question word, then the exact fact
Cause and Effect	Why does ___ happen?	Find the signal word; say ___ happened, so ___
Sequence	Which ___ happened first?	Number the steps; find the one that follows
Summarize	Which sentence best summarizes the selection?	Who or what, plus what happens, in one sentence
Vocabulary in Context	What does the word ___ mean in this sentence?	Cover the word; test each choice in the sentence
Reference Words	What does the word they, it, or this refer to?	Put each noun in place of the small word
Complete a Sentence	Which word best completes the sentence?	Read the whole sentence; check meaning and grammar
Inference	What does the passage suggest about ___?	Underline two clues; choose the answer with proof
Text Evidence	Which sentence best supports the idea that ___?	Find the sentence that PROVES the idea
Author's Purpose	Why did the author write this passage?	Inform, persuade, entertain, or explain how?
Paragraph Purpose	What is the main purpose of paragraph ___?	Say the paragraph's job in one verb
Comparison	What is one way that ___ and ___ are similar?	Make a two-column list; check both

Type	It sounds like	Do this
Character or Speaker	Why does ____ do or say ____?	Find what the person wants and says
Character's Feelings or Motives	How does ____ feel about ____?	Match the clues to a feeling word
Identify a Picture or Object	Which picture shows ____?	Check every clue in the description
Analyze a Visual	Which statement describes the information in the graph?	Read the title, labels, then the numbers
Understand an Explanation	How does ____ work?	Number the stages in order

For the teacher: how to use this guide